Raw Materials Out, Machines In: Kazakhstan's Trade with China, 2020-2025

Chingiz Bakytzhanov
Independent research brief, October 2026

Summary. This brief looks at goods trade between Kazakhstan and China from 2020 to 2025. According to Kazakhstan's official statistics, trade more than doubled over the period, from $15.4 billion to $34.1 billion, and China's share of Kazakhstan's foreign trade rose from 18.1% to 23.7%. The structure of trade, however, has barely changed: Kazakhstan exports mostly raw materials and imports machinery, electronics and vehicles. Since 2023 Kazakhstan has run a trade deficit with China, which reached $3.7 billion in 2025.

1. Introduction

China has become one of Kazakhstan's most important economic partners, and its role keeps growing. This brief asks three simple questions: what Kazakhstan sells to China, what it buys from China, and how the balance between the two has changed over the last six years.

2. Data

The main series come from Kazakhstan's official statistics (the Bureau of National Statistics, the Ministry of Trade and Integration and the State Revenue Committee), as published by government bodies and national media [1-6]. Data on goods by category are Kazakhstan's figures reported to UN Comtrade [8]. China publishes its own trade figures [1, 7]. They differ markedly from Kazakhstan's, so they are discussed separately in Section 4 and are not mixed with the Kazakh series. Figures for 2020 and 2021 come from news reports citing official bodies and are less reliable than later years.

3. Findings

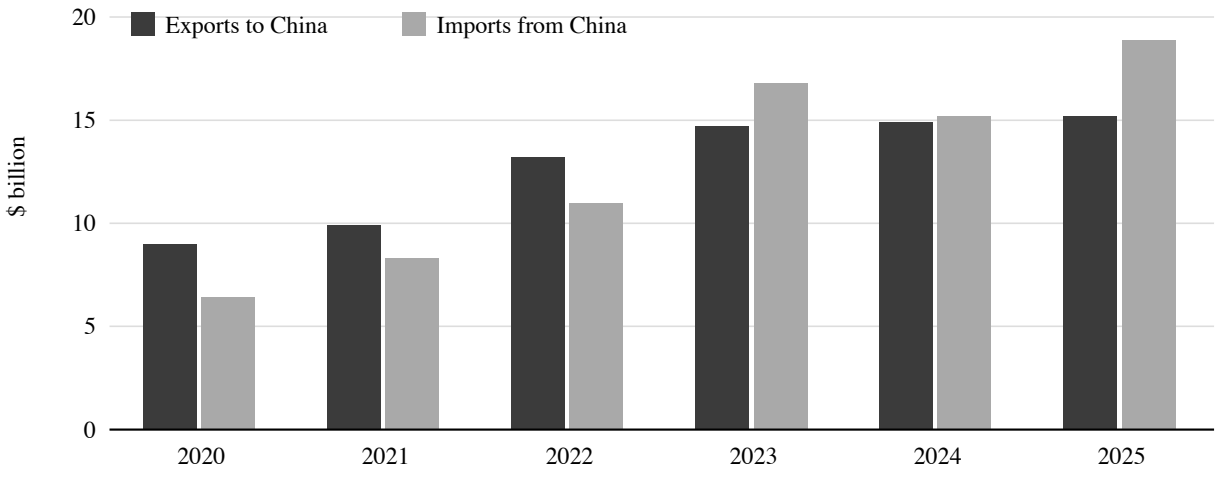
Table 1. Kazakhstan's goods trade with China, $ billion (Kazakh data)

	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
Exports to China	9.0	9.9	13.2	14.7	14.9	15.2
Imports from China	6.4	8.3	11.0	16.8	15.2	18.9
Total trade	15.4	18.2	24.2	31.5	30.1	34.1
Balance	+2.6	+1.6	+2.2	-2.1	-0.3	-3.7

Note: total trade for 2022 is the sum of exports and imports; the ministry reported "more than $24 billion". The 2023 import figure is an early estimate that was later revised to about $15.4 billion. Sources: [1]-[6].

Trade grew in almost every year, with the only pause in 2024, when turnover stayed at about $30 billion. Growth was driven mostly by imports. Between 2020 and 2025 imports from China nearly tripled, from $6.4 billion to $18.9 billion, while exports rose by about two thirds, from $9.0 billion to $15.2 billion (Figure 1).

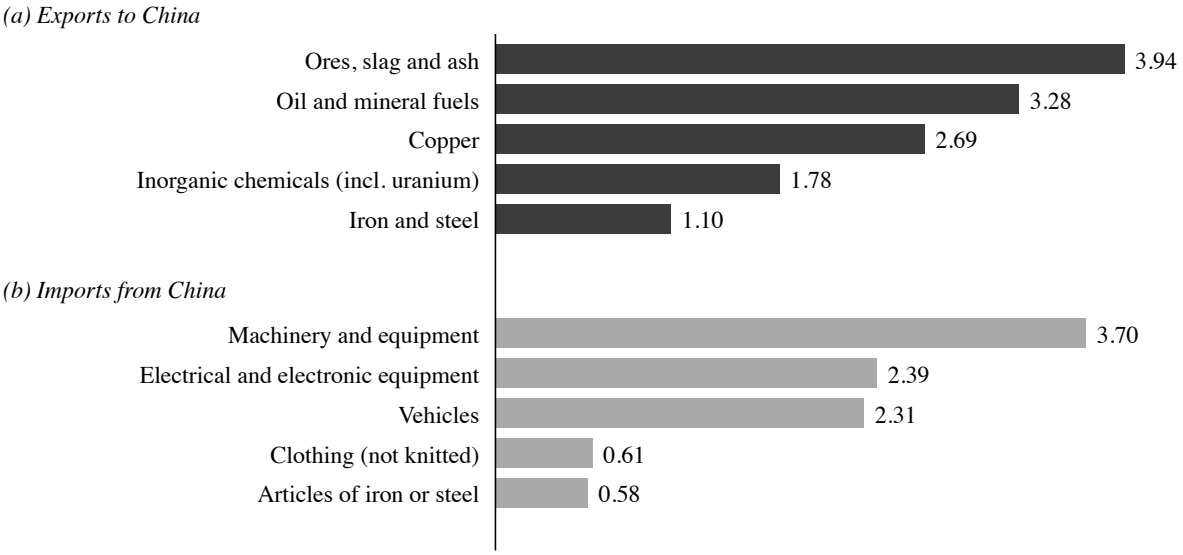
Figure 1. Kazakhstan's exports to and imports from China, 2020-2025, $ billion



As a result, the balance changed sign. Kazakhstan had a surplus with China of $2.6, $1.6 and $2.2 billion in 2020, 2021 and 2022, but it has been in deficit since 2023. In 2025 the deficit reached $3.7 billion, as imports grew by 24% and exports by only 2%.

The composition of trade explains much of this pattern (Figure 2). Kazakhstan's five largest exports to China in 2024 were ores, slag and ash, oil and fuels, copper, inorganic chemicals including uranium compounds, and iron and steel. All five are raw materials or products of primary processing, so their value depends heavily on world commodity prices. Its largest imports, by contrast, were finished goods: machinery and equipment ($3.7 billion), electronics ($2.4 billion) and vehicles ($2.3 billion).

Figure 2. Top five product groups in Kazakhstan's trade with China, 2024, $ billion



Source: Kazakhstan's data reported to UN Comtrade, via Trading Economics [8].

4. A note on the statistics

The two countries record the same trade very differently. China reports $48.7 billion of trade with Kazakhstan in 2025, compared with $34.1 billion in Kazakhstan's own data [2, 7]. Most of the gap is on the Chinese export side: in 2024 China recorded $28.0 billion of goods sent to Kazakhstan, while Kazakhstan recorded only $15.2 billion arriving from China [1]. Such "mirror statistics" gaps usually

come from goods passing through third countries, different valuation methods and under-declared imports. Any analysis of this trade should therefore state clearly whose data it uses.

5. Author's view

I think it is not good that Kazakhstan sells China mainly raw materials, because this makes our economy heavily dependent on resources that will not last forever. I also see the trade deficit as a concern, because Kazakhstan now relies on China for machinery, equipment and technology. From what I have seen, much of the equipment in Kazakh factories and hospitals is Chinese. At the same time, these imports bring technology that Kazakhstan needs, so the answer is not to trade less with China, but to develop the relationship further and learn to produce more of these goods at home.

References

1. Embassy of the Republic of Kazakhstan in the People's Republic of China. Trade and economic cooperation (2024 data, SRC and GACC). https://www.gov.kz/memleket/entities/mfa-beijing/activities/2110?lang=en
2. Association of Financiers of Kazakhstan. Kazakhstan-China commodity turnover, March 2026 (BNS data). https://afk.kz/2026/03/Kazakhstan-China-Commodity-Turnover-March2026.pdf
3. Kazinform. Trade turnover between Kazakhstan and China exceeded $31 billion in 2023. https://www.inform.kz/ru/tovarooborot-mezhdu-kazahstanom-i-kitaem-v-2023-godu-previsil-31-mlrd-d0a0bc
4. The Astana Times. Trade between China, Central Asian states reach $32.1 billion in 2022 (April 2023). https://astanatimes.com/2023/04/trade-between-china-central-asian-states-reach-32-1-billion-in-2022/
5. Kapital.kz. Kazakhstan's foreign trade and trade with China in 2021 (2022). https://kapital.kz/economic/104880/kak-razvivayut-sya-torgovyye-otnosheniya-kazakhstana-i-kitaya.html
6. Inbusiness.kz. Trade growth, exports and the opening of the Chinese market for Kazakhstan. https://inbusiness.kz/ru/news/rost-torgovli-eksport-i-otkrytie-kitajskogo-rynka-dlya-kazahstana-chto-govoryat-cifry
7. PwC China. Invest in Kazakhstan (April 2026), citing the General Administration of Customs of China. https://www.pwccn.com/zh/issues-based/invest-in-kazakhstan-apr2026.pdf
8. Trading Economics. Kazakhstan exports to China; Kazakhstan imports from China (UN Comtrade). https://tradingeconomics.com/kazakhstan/exports/china